

Work from home: understanding boundary management profiles using boundary-fit perspective

Neerja Kashive and Brijesh Sharma
Ves Business School, Mumbai, India, and

Vandana Tandon Khanna
KJ Somaiya Institute of Management Studies and Research, Mumbai, India

Abstract

Purpose – The recent COVID-19 pandemic has (triggered) lots of interest in work from home (WFH) practices. Many organizations in India are changing their work practices and adopting new models of getting the work done. The purpose of the study to look at the boundary-fit perspective (Ammons (2013) and two factors, namely, individual preferences (boundary control, family identity, work identity and technology stress) and environmental factors (job control, supervisor support and organizational policies). These dimensions are used and considered to create various clusters for employees working from home.

Design/methodology/approach – K-mean clustering was used to do the cluster analysis. Statistical package for social sciences 23 was used to explore different clusters based on a pattern of characteristics unique to that cluster, but each cluster differed from other clusters. Further analysis of variance test was conducted to see how these clusters differ across three chosen outcomes, namely, work-family conflict, boundary management tactics used and positive family-to-work spillover effect. The post hoc test also provided insights on how each cluster differs from others on these outcomes.

Findings – The results indicated four distinct clusters named boundary-fit family guardians, work warriors, boundary-fit fusion lovers and dividers consistent (with previous) research. These clusters also differ across at least two major outcomes like boundary management tactics and positive spillover. The high control cluster profiles like Cluster 3 (boundary-fit fusion lovers) and Cluster 4 (dividers) showed low technostress and higher use of boundary management tactics. Cluster 3 (boundary-fit fusion lovers) and Cluster 1 (boundary-fit family guardians) having high environmental influencers also showed higher positive family-to-work spillover.

Research limitations/implications – Because this study is very specific to the Indian context, a broad generalization requires further exploration in other cultural contexts. The absence of this exploration is one of the limitations of this study. On the culture continuum, countries may vary from being individualistic on one extreme to being collectivistic on the other extreme. Interaction of these two cultural extremities with the individual and the environmental dimension, as espoused in this research, can be examined further in a different cultural setting.

Originality/value – This study has extended the work of Ammons (2013) and added external influencers as a dimension to the individual preferences given by (Kossek 2016), and created the cluster for employees in the Indian context. This study has demonstrated the importance of reduced technostress, and the use of boundary management tactics (temporal and behavioral) leads to positive family-to-work spillover. It has also emphasized the relevance of organization policies and supervisor support for better outcomes in WFH.

Keywords Work from home, Boundary-fit, Work-family conflict, Boundary management tactics, Positive spillover, Cluster analysis

Paper type Research paper



1. Introduction

The recent emergence of COVID-19 has led to a global crisis hitting many service industries (Suneson, 2020) and thereby disrupting markets and service ecosystems (McKinsey, 2020).

This disruption has compelled people to work from home (WFH), and consequent to this, many organizations have changed their human resource (HR) policies to accommodate these unforeseen changes (Carnevale and Hatak, 2020). Work from home (WFH) has become the new normal. Individuals are adopting technology and also learning new skills to remain updated and communicate virtually. This has led to renewed interest in work from home phenomenon (WFH). It is well documented that technological innovation, the rise of dual-income families and globalization have been the drivers of the integration of work and nonwork domains (Rothbard and Ollier-Malaterre, 2016). There is growing interest and research in the dynamics of integration of work and nonwork settings and how it affects employee well-being and their health, but the finding in many of the studies are inconclusive (Allen *et al.*, 2014; Rothbard and Ollier-Malaterre, 2016).

Pre COVID-19, WFH was in infancy in India, and the general populace was not very warm to the concept of WFH; and also, companies were not very receptive to WFH as a workplace arrangement option. COVID-19 has compelled Indian companies to use WFH as a workplace arrangement in a very crude way to tide over the COVID-induced disruption. WFH has moved from the fringes to become a mainstream workplace arrangement, and it seems it has gained permanency. Looking at the new normal, which includes “future of work” and “role of office” leads to concerns about well-being and mental health (Guest *et al.*, 2021). There is a lot of learning for managers and organizations to create the right support during this pandemic (Kirchner *et al.*, 2021). The current study provides insight and a direction to the practitioners and organizations about the importance of organizational support to employees who are performing their tasks in the WFH kind of workplace arrangement. The research study also gives a direction that using and generalizing, one size fits all, approach in managing the new WFH workplace arrangement would not yield optimum results. A specific strategy for each cluster and a calibrated approach for each cluster would be more desirable.

Although work to nonwork integration can bring positive spillover in the individuals leading to higher enrichment (Powell and Greehaus, 2010), work to nonwork integration can also lead to negative spillover in the individuals leading to more conflict (Hecht and Allen, 2009; Kossek *et al.*, 2012; Powell and Greenhaus, 2010; Wepfer *et al.*, 2018). Teleworking can also lead to higher work-family conflict (WFC) due to overlapping roles in the work and family domain (Madsen, 2003). Apart from the contradictions in the studies concerning the benefit and the maladies of the abovementioned integration, there is a limited understanding of how technology and its usage outside working hours are affecting work and nonwork outcomes (Boswell and Olson-Buchanan, 2007). The traditional work and home environment are divided by temporal, physical and psychological boundaries. Working from home has changed (blurred) the previously set boundaries like physical, psychological and temporal between work and family domain (Greer and Payne, 2014). WFH has blurred these boundaries and made them porous, and in the absence of proper boundary management tactics, we have instances of WFC. Given the scale of adoption of WFH and the ensuing WFC, there is evidence of the sparse attention given to how work and nonwork boundaries are managed (Bulger *et al.*, 2007) and how they affect the major work-life outcomes (Kossek *et al.*, 2006).

A lot of work has been done in the work-life balance domain, and to reduce the WFC, individuals may try to reach some level of work-family balance (Clark, 2000; Greenhaus *et al.*, 2003). Organizations are looking for ways to provide a workplace where employees can achieve work-life balance, and many companies have introduced “family-friendly practices” (FFP) to reduce the WFC (Lockwood, 2003). Often the benefit obtained from WFH is more stressed, like increased flexibility leading to better manage the demand for work and family at the same time (Gajendran and Harrison, 2007). It is considered that WFH brings

more work-life balance as it leads to more integration between work and family roles. For integrating or segmenting roles to create boundaries between work and family, two important factors like flexibility and permeability are discussed (Ashforth *et al.*, 2000; Clark, 2000). Flexibility is given by the extent to which boundary may contract or expand in time or space depending on the demand from one domain, whereas permeability is the degree to which elements from one domain may enter another domain (Clark, 2000). When boundaries have high flexibility and permeability, it leads to more integration between work and family roles. People may move from the work domain to the family domain and manage the border to achieve work-life balance.

A person-centered approach can be applied to identify different profiles having different styles of boundary management as a part of psychological behaviors forming a distinct pattern or clusters. Kossek and Lautsch (2008) divided the individuals into high control (fusion lovers, quality timers and work or family fisters) exhibiting high WFC and psychological distress than individuals with low boundary control (BC) (job warriors, captives and reactors). Kossek *et al.* (2012) have shown that the three characteristics of boundary management, cross-role interruption behavior, role identity salience and BC gave six possible styles: work warriors, family guardians, overwhelmed reactors, dividers, fusion lovers and nonwork eclectics. Kossek (2016) used BC, work-non work interruption behavior, career-family identity centralities, needing time for self and technological dependence to create four major clusters such as integrators, cyclers, separators and role fisters.

Ammons (2008) came up with a unique dimension and adopted a person-environment fit perspective, and investigated the alignment of individual boundary preferences and boundaries provided by the external environment or workplace. In the person-environment approach, when there is the alignment of environmental conditions like workplace policies and practices with individual boundary preferences, it results in “boundary congruence” (Kreiner, 2009), which results in reducing conflict among work-family domain (Chen *et al.*, 2009) and higher satisfaction and commitment for the job (Rothbard *et al.*, 2005).

The current research has extended this approach to divide the employees into various clusters and emphasized the role of organization support as an external predictor for creating a positive family-to-work spillover for work from home (WFH). Based on the boundary fit perspective, two factors, namely, individual preferences (BC, family identity, work identity and technology dependence) and environmental factors (job control, supervisor support and organizational policies) are used to categorize the individuals into different clusters. The organizations can use the characteristics of the different clusters to understand the employee’s behavior and configure strategies to manage them. These clusters are also compared for WFC, different boundary management tactics (temporal, physical, behavioral, communicative) and positive spillover from family to work. WFC was seen to be high in all the clusters, and temporal and behavioral tactics were more used by the particular clusters with more positive family-to-work spillover.

This study has two important contributions to make. First, it investigates both individual factors as well as environmental factors based on the boundary fit perspective given by Ammons (2013) to divide individuals into various clusters, and second, it compares both positive and negative behavioral outcomes for all these clusters such as WFC, family-work boundary tactics and works positive spillover.

Key research questions

RQ1. Can we use a boundary fit perspective with both individual preferences (BC, family identity, work identity and technology adoption) and environmental

factors (job control, supervisor support and organizational support) to create clusters for individuals working from home (WFH)?

- RQ2. Do clusters based on individual preferences (BC, family identity, work identity and technology adoption) and environmental factors (job control, supervisor support and organizational support) differ across WFC, family-work boundary tactics and work positive spillover?

2. Literature review

2.1 *The theoretical perspective of boundary management*

When looking at the boundary management related to work and nonwork, two important theories with different origins are studied (Allen *et al.*, 2014). These are boundary theory (Ashforth *et al.*, 2000; Allen *et al.*, 2014; Nippert Eng, 1996), which focuses on the work-life domain, and border theory (Clark, 2000), which focuses on the work and family domain. As per these theories, individuals are forced to set boundaries to balance their work and family roles. Some create a boundary to segment the roles, whereas others create weaker boundaries to integrate the roles.

The boundary theory and border theory both investigate how individuals manage to set boundaries between work and their families. Although boundary theory takes up the sociological and cognitive perspective to understand individual learning about setting boundaries and its implications on social life. It dwells into the interaction between work and family and how people put meaning to these two aspects in their life (Nippert-Eng, 1996) and how they can change their roles when moving from one domain to another (Ashforth *et al.*, 2000; Desrochers and Sargent, 2004) the border theory focusses on the transition from one aspect to other and managing the border between them (Clark, 2000).

Most researchers have used a variable level approach by taking independent variables (choice for integration/segmentation) and outcome variables (WFC) as per (Rothbard *et al.*, 2005). Others have used a continuum to describe various characteristics of individuals using a mix of approaches or remain in extreme ends of the continuum (Kossek and Lautsch, 2008; Bulger *et al.*, 2007; Kossek *et al.*, 2012). They have also suggested the directionality to these concepts as to if the individual is integrating or segment from work to family or family to work (Kossek and Lautsch, 2008; Ashforth *et al.*, 2000; Kossek *et al.*, 2012). Boundary scholars (Ashforth *et al.*, 2000; Kossek *et al.*, 2005; Nippert-Eng, 1996; Kreiner, 2006; Kossek *et al.*, 1999) have also differentiated between desired and actual boundaries. “Enacted boundaries” are the actual demarcation individual makes, whereas “boundary preferences” are the boundary they desire to have. As per (Kossek *et al.*, 2005; Kossek and Lautsch, 2008) the preferred boundary can be a part of the enactment boundary.

Another aspect studied is the role of flexibility and permeability affecting the boundaries between the two domains (Ashforth *et al.*, 2000; Clark, 2000). Flexibility is the expansion and contraction of the boundary in time and space as the demand varies for one domain over the other (Clark, 2000). The permeability of the boundary is the extent of other domain elements entering into the phenomenon (Clark, 2000). The boundary with a high level of flexibility and permeability leads to higher integration of roles between work and nonwork domains. The three borders that work between work and family domains are temporal, physical and psychological (Clark, 2000). Preference for segmentation/integration also leads to the use of work-related technology in nonwork time (Park *et al.*, 2011; Piszczek, 2017).

2.2 Person-centered approach

A person-centered approach can be applied to boundary management, which can be used to identify different profiles having various styles of boundary management as a part of distinct psychological behaviors pattern. The person-centered approach can divide individuals into distinct clusters but different clusters differing from other clusters (Sinclair *et al.*, 2005). This approach considers boundary management as a holistic process having multiple aspects existing together.

Kossek and Lautsch (2008) divided the individuals into high control (fusion lovers, quality timers and work or family fisters), showing high WFC and psychological distress than individuals with low BC (job warriors, captives and reactors). Kossek *et al.* (2012) identified that the three characteristics of boundary management are cross-role interruptions behaviors, role identity salience and BC. Cross-role interruption behaviors are the extent to which an individual allows interruptions from one role to another. Role identity centrality shows the relative value individual places on his or her different identities. Perceived BC is the amount of control one perceives to have over his or her boundary environment. Combining all these three factors Kossek *et al.* (2012) gave six possible styles: work warriors, family guardians, overwhelmed reactors, dividers, fusion lovers and nonwork eclectics.

Bulger *et al.* (2007) created four clusters using boundary strengths of flexibility and permeability. Although Cluster 1 had high boundary strength and preferred high integration, Cluster 2 refereed preferred integration over-segmentation but did not have a strong urge to do so. Cluster 3 was neutral on all the boundary strength, but a low score for work flexibility and Cluster 4 was high on work flexibility and permeability but low on family flexibility and permeability

Kossek (2016) used BC, work-non work interruption behavior, career-family identity centralities, needing time for self and technological dependence to create four major clusters such as integrators, cyclers, separators and role fisters. Further strategies for self-management for personal BC in terms of physical, mental and social were suggested. Strategies for leaders and organizations to manage and support boundary styles were listed.

2.3 Boundary-fit perspective

Ammons (2008) came up with a unique perspective and suggested that boundary preferences and enactment are different but interrelated, and their relation to boundary-fit leads to various outcomes like WFC and work-life balance. This approach adopts a person-environment fit perspective and investigates the alignment of individual boundary preferences and boundaries provided by the external environment or workplace. In the person-environment approach, when there is the alignment of environmental conditions like workplace policies and practices with individual boundary preferences, it results in "boundary congruence" (Kreiner, 2009), which results in reduced conflict among work-family domain (Chen *et al.*, 2009) and higher satisfaction and commitment for the job (Rothbard *et al.*, 2005).

Allen *et al.* (2014) introduced boundary management styles using integration and segmentation continuum and distinguished between boundary preferences and enactment. Boundary preferences refer to the desired level of integration and segmentation (Ammons, 2013; Kreiner, 2006), whereas boundary enactment refers to the individual actual degree of integration and segmentation, which he or she achieves to fulfill his work and nonwork roles (Allen *et al.*, 2014). As per Allen *et al.* (2014), boundary management preferences and enactment for integration and segmentation are related to physical, psychological and behavioral aspects of the boundary between work and nonwork domains.

Ammons (2013) suggests that instead of focusing on the level of congruence between outside environmental conditions and boundary preference (Kreiner, 2009; Rothbard *et al.*, 2009), the researcher should investigate the process of environmental conditions affecting preferences and enactment. The boundary-fit approach can influence outcomes like WFC, work-life balance, job satisfaction, commitment and turnover intentions. Though already studies have focused on the boundary and above outcomes, the level of fit between actual and desired boundaries may provide a better understanding.

Ammons (2013), through a qualitative approach, studied the employees working in the environment, which facilitated flexibility in the context of the time (when) and place (where) they work and observed four dominant styles. The first style, called “protecting family” kept work away from family, and the second was called “above and beyond” and showed absence to little integration of family into the work domain. The second category had two subgroups, “eager above beyonders” who were completely engrossed in work and enjoyed it, whereas “reluctant above and beyonders” were not happy about integrating. The third category was called “enhancing family” as they aligned family responsibility into work, and the fourth category was called “holistic boundaries” as they could manage both work and family well lead a balanced life. Table 1 shows the various cluster suggested by the researcher in boundary management research.

Boundary management styles can be divided into various groups depending upon the following two factors, namely, individual preferences and environmental influencers. The individual preferences talk about the factors chosen at the individual level such as BC, work and family identity and technostress, whereas environmental factors are outside related to the job, supervisor and organizational policies.

2.3.1 *Individual preferences*

2.3.1.1 Boundary control. BC differs from identities as they focus on understanding of managing and controlling boundaries and do not investigate any personality traits. As per Clark (2000), flexibility is the degree to which people expand or contract the level of the boundary they have created. Karasek (1979) suggested job strain model can be used to apply to WFH as stress is created when an individual is not able to manage the demand of the environment when freedom to control job/job demand is not granted to him/her. The individuals having a high level of perceived BC will have a belief that they may manage time, frequency and direction of the crossing of boundaries to better fit their identities to the role, whereas individuals showing low control may feel that they cannot manage the crossing of boundaries to fit the identity given for each role.

2.3.1.2 Identity centrality of work and family roles. The role identity theory (Burke and Reitzes, 1991) can be used to explain role centrality, which investigates how an individual puts relative value to his or her identity in terms of investing time and energy in a given role. Many researchers believe that almost all the employees perceive themselves as having high family identity than work identity (Casper *et al.*, 2007; Routhausen, 1999). People differ as to how they give importance to different roles. Some people have a high family identity wherein they are family-centric, whereas some people place greater importance on career identity, prioritizing work-related tasks over family and are work-centric. Dual-centricity people are those who focus on both tasks related to work and family and have an equal identity for both job and family (Lobel and St. Clair, 1992).

2.3.1.3 Technological stress. The spread of information and communication technology (ICT) has increased the flexibility and permeability of work-family boundaries as the availability of communication devices like smart-phone and tablets are allowing people to work from home, providing flexible work schedules (Valcour and Hunter, 2005). In their study for IBM, Hill *et al.* (2003) have shown that working via ICT has provided a lot of

Table 1.
Framework for
clusters based on
individual
preferences

Sr. No.	Authors	Integration →Segmentation					
		Cluster 1	Cluster 2	Cluster 3	Cluster 4	Cluster 5	Cluster 6
1	Bulger <i>et al.</i> (2007)	Integrators	Somewhat work integrator and somewhat personal life segmentor Work or family fisters	Neutral (Midpoint of segmented-integrator) Quality timers	Segmentor (work integrators/ personal life segmentor)		
2	Kossek and Lautsch (2008)	Fusion lovers					
3	Kossek <i>et al.</i> (2012)	Work warrior	Overwhelmed Reactive	Family Guardians	Fusion lovers Dual-centric integrator	Divider Dual-centric separator	Nonwork-electics other-centric
4	Ammons (2013)	Holistic	Enhanced family	Above and beyond	Protect family		
5	Kossek (2016)	Integrators	Cycler	Role fister	Separators		

flexibility to employees in scheduling their tasks. But it is also observed that using ICT can also lead to increased workload and WFC due to interference in personal lives (Kurland and Bailey, 1999; Mirchandani, 1999).

Technostress is caused by the use of technology resulting from stimuli, events and demands that cause stress (Ayyagari *et al.*, 2011; Ragu-Nathan and Tu, 2008). Tarafdar *et al.* (2007) have given five ICT related stress: technology overload – making employees work more, techno invasion – ICT impacting employees personal lives, techno complexity – creating a mindset of not being competent, techno uncertainty – constant changing and upgradation of technology and techno security – the perception of losing a job due to continuous changes in technology.

Technostress may be caused due to three reasons: individual differences, technology-related perception and organizational characteristics (Tu *et al.*, 2005). Individual characteristics such as younger, male, lower education, inexperience for computer usage and lower level of computer efficacy and self-confidence may lead to higher technostress (Ragu-Nathan *et al.*, 2008; Shu *et al.*, 2011). Organizational characteristics may include technology dependency, centralization, degree of innovation, literacy and technology support (Shu *et al.*, 2011; Wang *et al.*, 2008). Technology characteristics such as degree individual accessibility, anonymity and continuous change also increase stress (Ayyagari *et al.*, 2011). Ollier-Malaterre *et al.* (2019) looked into the spatial, temporal, and relational boundaries for work and family and usage of technology to manage the same.

2.3.2 Environment influencers

2.3.2.1 Psychological job control. Kossek *et al.* (2006) proposed a psychological job control scale, based on Hackman and Oldham's (1980) job control scale, measuring job characteristics of how individuals perceive control of their work. The study found that the perception of an individual of having control over where, when and how work will be done predicts conflict between work and family more than how these can be integrated through organizational policies (Kossek *et al.*, 2006).

2.3.2.2 Supervisor support. The organizations that provide support in working hours scheduling and flexibility may give authority to supervisors who decide on workload and stress generated from work (Beehr *et al.*, 2003). As the supervisor plays an important role in managing the WFC, it becomes crucial for an organization to study the supervisor's behavior influencing these aspects of employee work (Hopkins, 2005). Supervisor support, which is a source of social support, is related to a lower level of work-family conflict (Frye and Breugh, 2004; Lapierre and Allen, 2006; Thomas and Ganster, 1995) and a higher level of positive spillover between work and family (Thompson and Prottas, 2006). Supervisor support also leads to higher job satisfaction and is negatively related to turnover intentions (Thomas and Ganster, 1995; Thompson and Prottas, 2006).

Family supportive supervisor behavior (FSSB) is defined as the behavior shown by the supervisor which supports family and includes emotional support, role modeling, instrumental support and creative work-family management (Kossek *et al.*, 2007). FSSB has been defined as where supervisors empathize with employees for having a work-family balance (Thomas and Ganster, 1995).

2.3.2.3 Organizational policies. Person environment (P-E) fit reveals that person and environment both influence not only individually but also interact and affect the individual outcomes (Harrison, 1978; Kulka, 1979; Stone and Hollenbeck, 1984). The preference supplies' perspective considers how the environment satisfies personal needs, values and preferences (Kristof, 1996). As the workplace environment provides the desired supplies, the fit is achieved as contrary to when the preferred supplies are provided in a small amount or large amount, leading to the mismatch. As per P-E fit theory, the match will lead to a reduction in

conflict and lower stress and improved well-being, whereas mismatch will lead to the exact opposite effect.

Family supportive organizations will always be considerate to the nonwork life of employees by their policies and procedure and, in effect, send the message across all the employees that nonwork responsibilities are valued. Allen (2001) showed that employees working in family-supportive organizations have less work interfering with family, even after controlling other variables like family-supportive supervision and family-friendly benefits. Organizations having a culture promoting positive work-family integration have been also associated with higher job satisfaction and organizational commitment, and lower turnover intentions (Allen, 2001). Gordon *et al.* (2007) have found that supportive culture integrating both aspects of work and family leads to lower WFC and higher job satisfaction, and Lapierre and Allen (2006) have shown the critical role of a supportive supervisor in managing WFC and high overall well-being. Mesmer-Magnus and Viswesvaran's (2006) meta-analysis also confirmed the negative relation between the perception of supportive work-family culture and WFC.

Hence, boundary fit perspective can be applied to take both individual preferences (BC, family identity, work identity and technology adoption) and environmental factors (job control, supervisor support and organizational support) to create clusters for individuals working from home (WFH). We can test the following hypothesis by using the cluster analysis technique using all the variables:

- H1a. Employees can be divided into different boundary management profiles based on individual preferences (BC, work identity, family identity and technology stress).
- H1b. Employees can be divided into different boundary management profiles based on environmental factors (job control, supervisor support and organizational support).

2.4 Work to family outcomes

2.4.1 Boundary management tactics. Kreiner *et al.* (2009) have identified four categories of tactics used by individuals for segmentation and integration. These four tactics are behavioral, temporal, physical and communication. Behavioral tactics use other people's support, technology usage, giving priority to the task and allowing permeability. Temporal tactics involve having control of time by blocking specific times and removing oneself from work/home tasks for some duration of time. Physical tactics use creating boundaries physically, manipulating physical space and managing physical artifacts. Although communication tactics use setting expectations by informing family members and confronting boundary violators. Sturges (2012) has further suggested techniques and activities which she called "crafting behaviors" as they are initiated by self and proactive behaviors. Three crafting behavior identified are physical, cognitive and relational. Physical crafting includes temporal, locational, choosing a convenient job and reducing the time for traveling. Cognitive crafting consists of defining work-life balance, deciding priorities for work and making choices to compromise. Although relational crafting included handling relationships in work, managing nonwork relationships. Carlson *et al.* (2019) found that job-focused and supervisor focused impression management (IM) behavior affects family-to-work-conflict and self-focused, coworker-focused and supervisor-focused IM behavior affects family-to-work enrichment.

2.4.2 Work-family conflict. Previous research has also shown that higher integration concerning greater permeability between the work domain and family domain leads to

higher conflict between work and family. Rothbard *et al.* (2005) found that individuals choosing segmentation may experience a lower level of negative work-family outcomes if the employer provides them with flexible working policies and support behaviors of boundary-crossing. Other researchers also suggest that the more the individual integrates boundaries (Kossek *et al.*, 2006) and uses flexibility in managing boundaries (Mathew *et al.*, 2010), the more conflict they would experience. Kreiner (2009) have shown that less the congruence between boundary-crossing behavior and salient identity between work and family more will be negative work-family outcomes, and others have confirmed the same as high control over the boundary (Kossek *et al.*, 2006) and schedules (Kelly and Moen, 2007) leads to more positive work-family outcomes.

2.4.3 Family-work positive spillover. Edwards and Rothbard (2000) have categorized positive spillover into four types and explained the process for the occurrence of this spillover. These four types of spillover are effect, value, skills and behavior. Each type of spillover occurs from work to family and family to work. Work-family positive spillover can be defined “as the transfer of positively valence effect, skill, behavior and values from the originating domain to the receiving domain and thus providing benefit to the receiving domain” (Edwards and Rothbard, 2000).

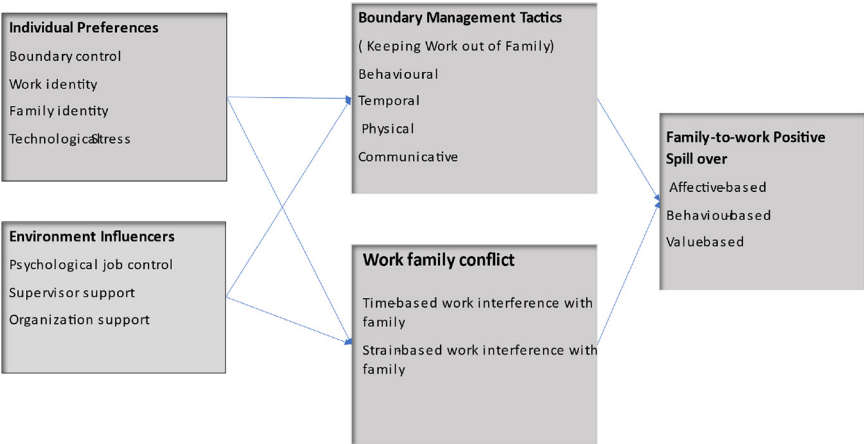
Yet another definition used is work-family facilitation, which describes the benefit of taking part in both the work and family (Wayne *et al.*, 2004, 2007). Work-family facilitation is defined as “the extent to which an individual’s engagement in one domain of life (e.g. work or family) yields developmental, affective, capital or efficiency gains that result in enhanced functioning in another life domain (e.g. family or work)” (Wayne *et al.*, 2004). The basic difference is that in positive spillover, there is the transfer of personal gains like skills, behavior and values from one aspect of life to another and transferring the benefit to the other aspect, whereas work-family facilitation does not only occur through personal gains but also capital gains like money, employment benefits and social contacts.

Greenhaus and Powell (2006) came up with the concept of enrichment, which occurs when there is the transfer of resources generated in one role like family to another role like work and that improves the quality of life. Hence, the construct positive spillover and even work-family facilitation can be put under the umbrella of work-family enrichment. Many studies have shown that positive spillover in work and family leads to greater satisfaction in job as well as family (Crouter, 1984; Edwards and Rothbard, 2000; Grzywacz *et al.*, 2002). Carlson *et al.* (2019) showed family-to-work enrichment is affected by supervisor-focused, coworker-focused and self-focused IM.

Based on individual preferences (BC, family identity, work identity and technology adoption) and environmental factors (job control, supervisor support and organizational support) if individuals can be divided into various clusters as the previous hypothesis. We can also look into if they also differ across work and family outcomes (WFC, family-work boundary tactics and family-work positive spillover) which are depicted in Figure 1 and can be tested by the following hypotheses:

- H2a.* Boundary management profiles based on individual preferences (BC, work identity, family identity and technology stress) and environmental factors (job control, supervisor support and organizational support) vary across the WFC.
- H2b.* Boundary management profiles based on individual preferences (BC, work identity, family identity and technology stress) and environmental factors (job control, supervisor support and organizational support) vary across family-work boundary tactics.

Figure 1.
Conceptual model
based on boundary-
fit perspective



H2c. Boundary management profiles based on individual preferences (BC, work identity, family identity and technology stress) and environmental factors (job control, supervisor support and organizational support) vary across family-to-work positive spillover.

3. Research methodology

3.1 Data and sample

The data were collected from people working in the COVID-19 period and working from home in Mumbai (India). A total of 186 data was collected. Demographic details concerning age, gender, number of dependents, number of rooms in the house and income were captured. It was seen that there were 53% male and 47% female and average they have worked for 30 h in a day. More than 80% lived in a house with only two bedrooms.

3.2 Measures

Individual preferences were captured by BC, which was measured through three items adapted from Kossek (2012) scale. Family identity and work identity had two items each and were measured by Kossek (2012). Technology adoption/stress was measured by two items each for techno overload, invasion, complexity and privacy adapted from Nimrod’s (2018) study.

Environmental preferences were measured by psychological Job control adapted from the (Kossek, 2006) scale. Supervisor support (Hammer et al., 2011) with four items for emotional support and three items for instrumental support. Organizational support (segmentation supplies) had four items adapted from (Kreiner, 2006).

WFC items were adapted from Carlson et al. (2000) scale having three items each for time-based and strain-based work-family interference. Boundary management tactics items included three items each for temporal, physical, behavioral and communicative and adapted from Carlson et al. (2015) study. Family-to-work positive spillover included four items for affective, four items for behavioral and three items for value-based based on Hanson et al. (2006).

3.3 Method

Scale reliability for each item was tested, and it was seen that Cronbach's alpha for all the scale items was more than 0.08. Cluster analysis was conducted to segregate individuals working from home in various categories based on their responses to the questionnaire. Cluster analysis helps in identifying and dividing respondents based on similar characteristics. This can be very helpful in the context of WFH as it provides an idea about the unique characteristics of each group. K-mean cluster analysis using statistical package for social sciences (SPSS) was used to explore different clusters based on a pattern of characteristics unique to that cluster but differing significantly from other clusters. Previous research has shown that cluster analysis is used in WFH studies and can provide very significant inputs. K-mean clustering is ideal when the number of clusters can be specified in the beginning. From the study of previous research, it was clear that a maximum six cluster solution can be achieved i.e. [Kossek et al. \(2012\)](#) have suggested six clusters for different individuals as per the boundary management approach. The K-means cluster analysis was run using six, five and four clusters and concluded that the four clusters solution was most ideal for explaining our theory considering two distinct aspects like individual preferences and environment influencers. All the variables used also significantly contributed to the cluster formation.

Further analysis of variance (ANOVA) test was conducted to see how these clusters differ across three chosen outcomes, namely, WFC, boundary management tactics used and positive family work spillover felt. The post hoc test also provided which clusters differ from others on these outcomes.

4. Results and findings

As shown in [Figure 2](#), four distinct clusters have emerged from the K-mean cluster analysis done in SPSS. The four clusters have clear cluster centers. They can be defined based on individual preferences (BC, work identity, family identity and technostress) and environmental influencers (job control, supervisor support and organization support). All the variables for individual preferences and environmental influencers are significant in defining clusters as they have high F -values, which are all significant, as shown in [Table 2](#). Individual preferences i.e. BC (47.00), work identity (11.84), family identity (43.10) and technostress (8.29), showed p values (0.00) as significant and environmental preferences i.e. job control (77.98), supervisor support (16.95) and organization support (22.88) showed p values (0.00) as significant. This led us to accept both hypotheses $H1a$ and $H1b$ and further name each cluster as per the unique characteristics they showcased concerning chosen variables.

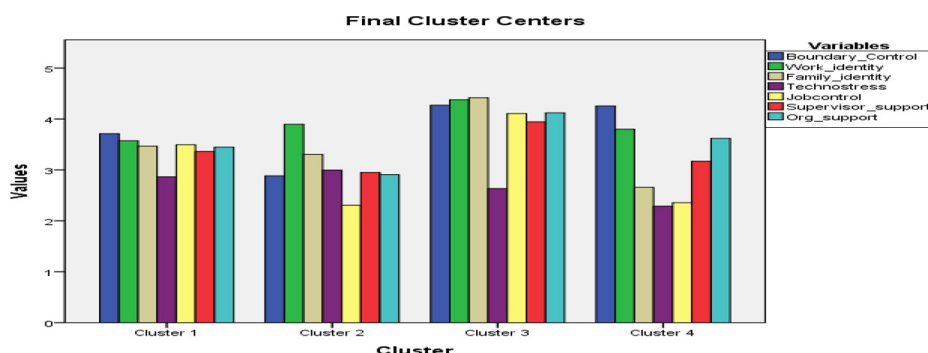


Figure 2.
Cluster centers for
different boundary
profiles

Table 2.
Mean and standard
deviation for
different boundary
management clusters

Boundary management dimensions	Low control		High control		F-values	Sig
	Cluster 1 <i>n</i> = 73	Cluster 2 <i>n</i> = 44	Cluster 3 <i>n</i> = 37	Cluster 4 <i>n</i> = 35		
	Boundary-fit family guardians	Work warriors	Boundary-fit Fusion lovers	Dividers		
Boundary_control	30.71 (0.57)	2.89 (0.66)	4.27 (0.58)	4.26 (0.62)	47.00	0.00
Work_identity	3.57 (0.62)	3.89 (0.67)	4.38 (0.59)	3.80 (0.82)	11.84	0.00
Family_identity	3.46 (0.65)	3.31 (0.64)	4.42 (0.69)	2.66 (0.70)	43.10	0.00
Technostress	2.87 (0.57)	2.99 (0.67)	2.63 (0.79)	2.28 (0.77)	8.29	0.00
Job control	3.49 (0.48)	2.31 (0.64)	4.11 (0.68)	2.35 (0.84)	77.98	0.00
Supervisor_support	3.36 (0.55)	2.95 (0.78)	3.94 (0.67)	3.17 (0.62)	16.95	0.00
Org_support	3.45 (0.63)	2.91 (0.76)	4.12 (0.63)	3.62 (0.63)	22.88	0.00

These clusters can be divided into clusters having profiles with either low or high control. Cluster 1 ($n = 73$) and Cluster 2 ($n = 44$) are low control clusters, whereas Cluster 3 ($n = 37$) and Cluster 4 ($n = 35$) are high control clusters. The mean values and standard deviations are shown in Table 2. These clusters are named based on their characteristics on the two chosen dimensions i.e. individual preferences (BC, work identity, family identity and technostress) and environmental influencers (job control, supervisor support and organization policies). The four clusters are named as boundary-fit family guardians, work warriors, boundary-fit fusion lovers and dividers based on previous frameworks given by Kossek *et al.* (2012), Kossek (2016) and Ammons (2013), as shown in Table 3.

Cluster 1 has characteristics with low BC ($M = 3.71$), high family identity ($M = 3.46$) and low technostress as individual preferences but has high environmental influencers like job control ($M = 3.49$), supervisor support ($M = 3.36$) and organization policies ($M = 3.45$). They are named as boundary-fit family guardians. This cluster has an average age of 30 years, male (48%), female (52%), married (60%), senior-level (45%) and junior-level (55%).

Cluster 2 has characteristics with low BC ($M = 2.89$), high work identity ($M = 3.89$) and low technostress, and have low environmental influencers like job control ($M = 2.31$), supervisor support ($M = 2.95$) and organization policies ($M = 2.91$). They are named as work warriors. This cluster has an average age of 30 years, male (55%), female (45%), married (60%), senior-level (57%) and junior-level (43%).

Cluster 3 has characteristics with high BC ($M = 4.27$), high family identity ($M = 4.42$) and work identity ($M = 4.38$) and low technostress as individual preferences but have high environmental influencers like job control ($M = 4.11$), supervisor support ($M = 3.94$) and organization policies ($M = 4.12$). They are named as boundary-fit fusion lovers. This cluster has an average age of 30 years, male (57%), female (43%), married (65%), senior-level (60%) and junior-level (40%).

Cluster 4 has characteristics with high BC ($M = 4.26$), low family identity ($M = 2.66$), work identity ($M = 3.80$) and technostress, and have low environmental influencers like job control ($M = 2.35$), supervisor support ($M = 3.17$) and organization policies ($M = 3.62$). They are named as dividers. This cluster has an average age of 28 years, male (54%), female (46%), married (55%), senior-level (40%) and junior-level (60%).

Table 4 shows the ANOVA test for various outcomes for these four clusters concerning WFC, the boundary management tactics used by them and the positive family-to-work spillover. It is seen that these clusters show high WFC, as a means for all these clusters were greater than 3.5, but it does not differ across them as F -value is 1.297 and p -value = 0.277. But the emerged clusters do differ across the other two outcomes, namely, boundary management tactics with F -value = 8.477 and p -value = 0.000 and positive family to work spill over with F -value = 7.487 and p -value = 0.000. Hence, $H2b$ and $H2c$ were accepted, whereas $H2a$ was rejected.

It is also observed that both Cluster 3 ($M = 3.80$) and Cluster 4 ($M = 3.47$) have the highest values for a mean and standard deviation for boundary management tactics.

Boundary management dimension	Individual preferences	
	High	Low
Environmental influencers	Cluster 3	Cluster 1
High	Boundary-fit fusion lovers.	Boundary-fit family guardians
Low	Cluster 4	Cluster 2
	Dividers	work warriors.

Table 3.
Clusters based on individual preferences and environmental influencers

Table 4.
Mean and standard
deviation for
different clusters for
various outcomes

Work-family outcomes	Low control		High control		F-values	Sig
	Cluster 1 n = 73	Cluster 2 n = 44	Cluster 3 n = 37	Cluster 4 n = 35		
Work-family outcomes	Boundary-fit family guardians	Work warriors	Boundary-fit Fusion lovers	Dividers		
Work_family_conflict	3.51(0.59)	3.66(0.61)	3.66(0.69)	3.42(0.78)	1.297	0.0277
Boundary_tactics	3.41(0.53)	3.19(0.53)	3.80(0.65)	3.47(0.49)	8.477	0.0000
Family_work_spillover	3.95(0.56)	3.80(0.68)	4.40(0.52)	3.90(0.65)	7.487	0.0000

Although Cluster 3 ($M = 4.40$) and Cluster 1 ($M = 3.95$) has also high mean values for a positive family-to-work spillover. The post hoc test showed that Cluster 3 differs from Clusters 1 and 2 for boundary management tactics and with all the other three clusters for the positive family-to-work spillover.

Further, when looking into the ANOVA test for the different boundary management tactics, it is seen that all tactics differ across the four clusters, as shown in Table 5. Cluster 3 has the highest mean values for all four boundary management tactics, namely, temporal_tactics ($M = 4.07$), physical_tactics ($M = 3.59$), behavioral_tactics ($M = 3.83$) and comm_tactics ($M = 3.73$). Cluster 4 has the highest mean values for three boundary management tactics, namely, temporal_tactics ($M = 3.69$), physical_tactics ($M = 3.46$) and behavioral_tactics ($M = 3.64$). Cluster 2 has a high mean value of $M = 3.21$ for communication tactics. Clusters 3 and 4 use temporal followed by behavioral tactics more than physical and communicative tactics.

The post hoc test showed that Cluster 3 differs from Clusters 1 and 2 for temporal_tactics, Cluster 2 for behavioral_tactics and with all the clusters for communication tactics. It is also seen that Cluster 2 differs from Clusters 3 and 4 for physical_tactics. Cluster 3 also showed a significant difference between Clusters 1 and 2 for affective positive spillover and all the other three clusters for behavioral as well as value-based positive spillover.

5. Discussions

COVID-19 situation has led many to work from home for an exceptionally long time in India, and organizations have also understood the need to support employees working from home in this era of new normal. In India, work from home is still not so popular, and there is a need for an organization to understand how they must change their work culture and mindset concerning WFH. One way of doing this is to design generalized policies and HR practices for all the employees working from home, and the second way would be to segregate employees based on various clusters and identify the characteristic of each cluster. Based on this cluster group and characteristics, devise the right policies and HR practices for each cluster to integrate them into a new work culture. The current research is focusing on bridging the gap between the theory and practice and emphasizing the designing of very specific strategies as per cluster characteristics.

The advantages of the latter would be phenomenal as it will allow the organization to focus on each group of a particular cluster and then understand their characteristics and design strategies as per their need. It would also lead to better results as strategies are targeted very specifically for each cluster in terms of their developmental area.

5.1 Theoretical implications

The study has three important contributions to make. First, it has applied the concept as suggested by Ammons (2013) for a boundary-fit perspective, which states that when looking at the boundary management studies, it is imperative to consider how individuals make efforts to align the individual preference with the external environment. The study has investigated the employees and divided them into various clusters as suggested by Kossek *et al.* (2012) and Kossek (2016) work by taking individual preferences (BC, work identity, family identity and technostress) and environmental influencers (job control, supervisor support and organization policies). There is no other study that has approached the boundary management profiles from both internal and external factors and looking at holistically the profiles.

Table 5.
Mean and standard
deviation for
different clusters for
boundary
management tactics

	Low control		High control		F-values	Sig
	Cluster 1 n = 73	Cluster 2 n = 44	Cluster 3 n = 37	Cluster 4 n = 35		
Boundary management tactics	Boundary-fit family guardians	Work warriors	Boundary-fit Fusion lovers	Dividers		
Temporal_tactics	3.67(0.70)	3.26 (0.79)	4.07(0.69)	3.69(0.67)	8.569	0.000
Physical_tactics	3.30 (0.76)	3.01(0.78)	3.59(0.90)	3.46(0.632)	4.220	0.006
Behavioral_tactics	3.51(0.69)	3.28(0.79)	3.83(0.91)	3.64(0.67)	3.771	0.012
Comm_tactics	3.18(0.74)	3.21(0.88)	3.73(0.87)	3.11(0.96)	4.354	0.005

The hypothesis *H1a* and *H1b* were accepted as all the variables under study i.e. individual preferences (BC, work identity, family identity and technostress) and environmental influencers (job control, supervisor support and organization policies), came out to be significant and contributed toward building four unique clusters different from each other. The study identified four important clusters, namely, boundary-fit family guardians, work warriors boundary-fit fusion lovers and dividers based on individual preferences (BC, work identity, family identity and technostress) and environmental influencers (job control, supervisor support and organization policies). These clusters align with the work of [Kossek et al. \(2012\)](#), [Kossek \(2016\)](#) and [Ammons \(2013\)](#). Clusters 1 and 2 are low control clusters, whereas Clusters 3 and 4 are high control clusters. Demographic details are also looked at for each cluster, and it was found that Cluster 1 (boundary-fit family guardians), which is high on family identity, has a higher population of female employees. Clusters 3 and 4 are low on technostress and show more positive family-to-work spillover.

The second contribution of this study is that it also compares the outcomes for all these clusters based on boundary fit perspectives like WFC, their boundary management tactics used by them and the positive family-to-work spillover. It was found that these clusters differ across boundary management tactics and family-to-work positive spillover but not concerning WFC, and hence, *H2b* and *H2c* were accepted but not *H2a*. Cluster 3 differs from Clusters 1 and 2 for boundary management tactics. Cluster 3 (boundary-fit fusion lovers) has the highest mean values for all four boundary management tactics, namely, temporal_tactics, physical_tactics, behavioral_tactics and comm_tactics, and were high on both individual preferences, as well as environmental influencers. Although Cluster 4 (dividers) also showed high mean values for three boundary management tactics, namely, temporal_tactics, physical_tactics and behavioral_tactics, and used these tactics to have control on the boundary between work and home. Both the clusters use temporal followed by behavioral tactics more than physical and communicative tactics.

The third major contribution of this study is understanding the positive family-to-work spillover among these clusters. Cluster 3 (boundary-fit fusion lovers) also showed a significant difference from Clusters 1 and 2 for affective positive spillover and all the other three clusters for behavioral as well as value-based positive spillover. It was seen that Cluster 3 is high on both individual preferences as well as environmental influencers; it had a better overall family-to-work positive spillover and differed significantly from other clusters on all the three-positive family-to-work spillovers, namely, affective, behavioral and value-based. Cluster 1 (boundary-fit family guardians), also high on environmental influencers, showed high value for the positive family to work spillover. This indicated that environment influencers do play a crucial role in deciding the positive family-to-work spillover.

6. Managerial implication

Clusters 3 and 4 are low on technostress, which is helping them to have a more positive family-to-work spillover as they do not feel technology is overloading or complex to handle and do not see that technology is invading and affecting their privacy. Organizations can also assist employees in handling technology-related stress, as this will reduce their anxiety and help in managing their work more efficiently from home. Some studies have focused on differences in individual behaviors when feeling technostress like young workers feel more technostress in terms of overload and invasion ([Ayyagari et al., 2011](#); [Tarafdar et al., 2007](#)), whereas senior workers are more impacted by inclusion, privacy and complexity (Nimod, 2017). This leads us to the fact that there is a need to integrate older workers by reducing the complexity of the technology used and creating more inclusive practices for the use of

technology, especially with the emergence of WFH culture. This can be achieved by segregating employees into a cluster based on demographics and then having the right strategy designed for them.

Cluster 3 (boundary-fit fusion lovers) have not only used individual preferences of controlling boundary and reducing technology-related stress but their perception about psychological job control as to when, where and how the job must be completed, supervisor support providing emotional as well as instrumental support and organization having family-friendly policies are also high. Cluster 1 (boundary-fit family guardians), also high on environmental influencers, showed high value for the positive family to work spillover. This cluster is characterized by high family identity and has more female employees than males. This provides the organization clear indications that the organization should design jobs that provide flexibility and autonomy and orient their supervisors to provide support and investigate the family-supportive organization policies to achieve positive family-to-work spillover leading to high productivity. The results support FSSB as given by [Hammer *et al.* \(2007, 2009\)](#) and [Kossek *et al.* \(2007\)](#), which has four dimensions: emotional support, instrumental support, role modeling and creative work-family management. More emphasis should be given to creative work-family management behavior as they are considered more strategic and innovative and are more supervisor-initiated activities to integrate work and family responsibilities ([Hammer *et al.*, 2007](#)). Coaching and mentoring programs can be designed for the supervisors who can be especially groomed to handle their team members who are battling with the uncertainty of working from home. FFP provided by organizations need to look into individual differences and focus on each cluster and their needs for integration and segmentation as suggested by previous research work ([Rau and Hyland, 2002](#); [Rothbard *et al.*, 2005](#)). FFP like flexitime, telecommuting, on-site childcare all have to be targeted as per different cluster needs

Cluster 3 (boundary-fit fusion lovers), high on both individual preferences, as well as environmental influencers, have shown high mean values for all four boundary management tactics, namely, temporal_tactics, physical_tactics, behavioral_tactics and comm_tactics followed by Cluster 4 (dividers), showing high mean values for three boundary management tactics, namely, temporal_tactics, physical_tactics and behavioral_tactics. These results emphasize the importance of using these tactics while working from home as the cluster, which is low in these tactics, also showed low value for the positive family to work spillover. So, if organizations want that the performance of employees should be improved, they have to focus on these tactics. It was also observed that both the clusters use temporal followed by behavioral tactics more than physical and communicative tactics. Temporal tactics refer to how time is managed by allocating specific time for work and home-related activities and removing oneself from another domain for that duration. Behavioral tactics investigate how individuals bring about changes in their behavior by asking for support from others, using technology more and prioritizing tasks. The training can be provided by the organization to improve on temporal and behavioral tactics, especially in those employee's clusters, which have low values like Clusters 1 and 2. The development of these tactics will go a long way to help employees working from home cope with the stress and burnout.

7. Limitation and future scope

The study is specific to India, and hence, the behavior of the variables in the study in other cultures is questionable. The culture may play an important role in deciding whether individual preferences or environmental influencers will play an important role. It is a well-

understood fact that some culture promotes individualistic culture while in many others, collectivist culture is embedded. Hence, there is a need to replicate this study in other cultural contexts to see its generalizability.

The future scope of this study could be many. First, the studies can explore more about environmental influencers other than those studied. In the era of technology adoption, especially in times of COVID-19 scenario, it becomes important to investigate how technostress can be reduced by the organization. In this study, technostress came low for both Clusters 3 and 4, having high BC. Future research can investigate how organizations can take initiatives to reduce technology-related stress in employees working from home and help in reducing WFC.

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About the authors

Neerja Kashive is presently working as associate dean-academics at VES's Institute of Management Studies and Research. She has completed her PhD from Mumbai University in the area of employer branding with the title, "Impact of Employer and Employee branding on Organizational attractiveness and Firm performance in IT sector in Mumbai". Her area of research focuses on employer branding, internal branding, brand loyalty, brand citizenship behavior, artificial intelligence, gamification and technology in HR. She is a certified HR analytics professional and conducts workshops and seminars. Neerja Kashive is the corresponding author and can be contacted at: nirja.kashive@ves.ac.in

Brijesh Sharma is an incisive professional with over 25 years of work experience. He has diverse experience ranging from operations to sales and marketing and also running various ventures. He has worked in Blue chip pharmaceutical companies like Lupin and Wockhardt. He is a graduate in

microbiology and MMS and PhD from the University of Mumbai. Professor Sharma has an interest in learning and teaching business research, strategic management, marketing and analytics. His research areas are corporate governance and technology in business.

Vandana Tandon Khanna is working as a professor at KJ Somaiya Institute of Management Studies and Research, Mumbai, in the Department of Marketing Management. She is a doctorate in services marketing from the Department of Management, Kurukshetra University, Kurukshetra, and a master in tourism management (MTM) Department of Tourism, Kurukshetra University Kurukshetra). She has around 14 years of diversified teaching experience. Her teaching and research interests are in the area of services marketing, CRM, customer satisfaction and loyalty, customer experience management and tourism and hospitality management.

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